

library of patchouli -- 終末

少女終末旅行 / Girls' Last Tour by Tsukumizu

9.5/10

start date: 6 november 2024

finish date: 22 november 2024

"絶望と、仲良く。"

"和绝望，和睦相处。"

"Befriending despair."

i enjoyed this one thoroughly. there is something about friends trying to survive the post-apocalyptic dystopian future hand in hand that strikes me deeply. definitely would recommend reading this as a break from everything but do expect it to get emotional if you have a soft spot for this genre like i do. i read this whilst travelling and it stuck with me all this while. thank you tsukumizu

=== all below shall be spoilers ===

the story follows chito (千戸) and yuuri (尤莉), two girls in their youth, as they embark on a journey for survival in a ruined world after everything was wiped in wars across the world. the world is separated into different layers, and increases in level of technological advancement as one moves up the layers. almost no flora and fauna from the past world (our current world) exists and the girls could only attempt to imagine what elephants and fish and such were like using whatever knowledge their grandfather imparted to them and reading books from the past era. the camera they were given showed a date of august 3230 to march 3231 so we are looking very far into a future.

the two girls travel in a kettenkrad and start from the bottom layer. they go up and experience bits of life as they tread through each layer up in a quest to reach the top layer (because grandfather told them to reach the top layer when they escaped). chito plays the role of the calm and rational one. she collects books and wrote a diary and drove and fixed the kettenkrad. yuuri is the extremely optimistic one of the two. she eats a bunch and is good at guns and carrying out strenuous activity

as they make it up the layers, they meet different people as well - other surviving humans just like them, except they are alone. they find kanazawa (金泽), a mapping enthusiast who hands them a camera. although in a sudden emergency he loses his maps he still persists in his endeavor and leaves. they also meet ishii (石井) the pilot-engineer. she stayed in a military base and has almost run out of food. she welcomed the company and sought help from the duo in completing her aircraft that she had been making in the past however many years. in her attempt

at flight afterwards the plane disintegrates in midair and she parachutes down, landing in the layer below. all the best ishii

they meet a few remaining sentient artificial intelligence machines as well. there is a robot tasked originally to take care of all the fish in the fish production area and has stayed true to its purpose, except there is only one fish remaining that it meticulously took care of. i think this parallels the robot and also the duo because the fish is, like them, stranded in the otherwise inanimate world.

they meet a power artificial intelligence "overseer" while attempting to travel up a lift to the upper layers. it begs the duo to end its machine life because it did not want to experience any more loneliness and despair. they do so and travel up the lift.

they also meet Nuko which they mistook for a cat. they later meet the grown form of nuko's species of beings. these guys can consume high-energy substances like missiles or camera operating systems and communicate through EM signals which sound like tunes. after draining a city of all its energy, these things open up their bodies and fly away with a form not unlike a trumpet mushroom and move on to purge other remaining cities of their remaining energy. when all cities have been "processed" the end will come and they will go into slumber again. nuko also mentions there is no sign of life detected in the lower layers meaning ishii and kanazawa are most likely gone.

i believe the story ends in a tragedy but it is presented in the most heartwarming and hopeful way. if i were to describe it in a sentence, it would be something along the lines of "it is the end of the world and that is alright as long as i have you by my side". maybe this sounds cliché but the story presents this troupe to its fullest through each and every interaction between the close-knit two girls as they embark on this journey

the story deals with many themes which are discussed half-jokingly by the duo. yuuri asks "dumb" questions sometimes and they both stop to think about it.

- hope

- seeing light after long periods of darkness (in multiple occasions) parallels their levels of hope after each encounter or layer they've gone by

- the initial tunnel, the pipe maze, the giant basement of robots

- war and destruction

- friendship, a companion and the hope it brings

- the priceless and delicate gift that is family

--- seeing how people used to live through the recorded photos of the camera and reliving memories of those in the previous eras

- the state of future and post-future culture

--- deciphering writings they found of the past (from our current world)

--- yuuri drawing a picture of the duo with yuuri carrying the fish and mentions this is likely the last piece of artwork in humanity's history

- mental state of being alone

--- chito breaks down once while in a hot water bath they made out of the kettenkrad. the despair overwhelms her and the duo hug as chito downs the last bottle of wine they have remaining

--- they hold hands while ascending the dark final steps and this warms my heart

- preservation of culture X survival?

--- the tragedy of burning books and important records from the past (and even the diary when they became desperate later on) in order to stay warm to survive

--- at the start, chito was bitter at yuuri for accidentally damaging one of the books and yuuri rebutted that they hadn't much use. chito later caved into burning whatever they could to stay alive in an almost numb and pragmatic fashion. she must've been heartbroken because she treasured those books so much to have carried them all the way

--- "are you burning that too?" (yuuri points at the diary)

--- "let's tear the notes on the maps out first."

--- "are you alright?" (yuuri concerned)

--- "i'm okay..."

--- "for our present circumstances... starting a fire to boil water is more important than the contents in the diary..." (chito's mental monologue)

- remembrance and forgetfulness

--- "maybe i am simply afraid of forgetting. it is as if i were in deep dreamless slumber... blank spots spouted in my memory..."

--- "but it is alright. because we wake up everyday nonetheless....."

--- "we are still alive."

- the purpose of life

--- and what becomes the purpose of life when civilisation disintegrates? what other thing to do when all that is left is to survive?

--- and what will they do after they reach the top layer where there is nothing?

my eyes filled with tears multiple times as i read the story because this is genuinely an emotional

ride that is certainly well executed. thank you tsukumizu.

i am writing this review a month after i first finished the story so i may be missing out a few things. nonetheless the emotions well up within me each time i experience this story and empathise with the protagonists. 9.5/10

some notes below

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a brief look into the setting of the story is given by moegirl and i find it very clear in illustrating the worldview:

前文明时期 (古代): 具有极高的科技水平, 建造了层叠都市以及超级兵器, 语言文字与现代一致。基本可以确定是现代文明的延续。由于未知原因而终结。没有留下任何影像资料。

后文明时期 (影像资料期): 剧中大部分文明遗迹及影像资料的来源。继承了古代的部分衣钵。科技大幅倒退, 但传承了相对普遍的电子技术和文化遗产, 文字未变形。尖端技术尤其是超级武器和层叠都市的建造与维护技术完全丧失。制造的物品与现代物品外形一致, 但被植入了极先进的电子技术。潜艇和照片机均来自这一时期。层叠都市进入无序建造状态 (可能有过小规模的建设, 比如某些承重柱和地下军用设施应该是在这一时期建造的) 前文明时期的部分超级武器被后文明时期拥有并封存 (这是二者具有关联性的一个证据) 在影像资料期的末期, 爆发了影像中的“全球性战争”, 并在战争后期解封了古代武器, 最后发射的电磁武器直接导致后文明时期 (即最后的全球性有组织社会) 的结束。

城邦时期 (衰落期): 战后历史时期的总称。由于电磁脉冲弹破坏了层叠都市的上下层交流功能, 各层内部开始分裂为大量政体各异的城邦国家。文化与科技水平严重倒退。神庙就是这一时期的产物。在战争中基盘被严重破坏, 大量功能难以为继, 资源愈发稀缺, 各层内部和上下层间爆发大量的局部战争。同时出现资源枯竭的上层向下层迁移的现象。在不间断的战争中科技水平不断倒退, 语言文字也随着教育体制的瓦解而日益变形, 并且随着战争和都市环境的恶化而不断减少, 常年的战争导致大量生物悉数灭绝, 残存的人类文明也逐渐走向黄昏。在城邦时期的末尾, 底层最后一批人类自相残杀的前夕, 千户和尤莉离开了底层, 开始向早已死寂的上层前进。

-- <https://zh.moegirl.org.cn/zh-hans/>

%E5%B0%91%E5%A5%B3%E7%BB%88%E6%9C%AB%E6%97%85%E8%A1%8C

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chapter names. i hope i can recall the happenings in it when i revisit this review in the future

01 星空 | 02 戦争 | 03 風呂 | 04 日記 | 05 洗濯 | 06 遭遇 | 07 都市 | 08 街灯

09 写真 | 10 寺院 | 11 住居 | 12 昼寝 | 13 雨音 | 14 故障 | 15 技術 | 16 離陸
17 迷路 | 18 調理 | 19 記憶 | 20 月光 | 21 螺旋 | 22 技術 | 23 水槽 | 24 生命
25 電車 | 26 波長 | 27 捕獲 | 28 文化 | 29 破壊 | 30 過去 | 31 接続 | 32 仲間
33 水路 | 34 怪我 | 35 美術 | 36 衣服 | 37 煙草 | 38 爆発 | 39 忘却 | 40 故郷
41 吹雪 | 42 宇宙 | 43 凶書 | 44 喪失 - 充電 - 雪玉 | 45 睡眠 | 46 沈黙 | 47 終末

CN translations for clearer understanding:

03: 洗澡

05: 洗衣

12: 午睡

16: 起飞

31: 连接

34: 受伤

41: 暴风雪

44 (3): 雪球

46: 沉默

===

c: "is this... the highest layer?"

y: "it must be. because... there is nothing above us anymore."

*

y: "hey... did we do the right thing?"

c: "by 'right thing'... do you mean whether we should have gave up sooner...? or went in a different direction... then maybe we could have found a warm place with plenty of food..."

y: "..."

the snowball fight between yuuri and chito was the greatest world war ever.
because 100% of all humans participated in it.

y: "but being alive is wonderful"

c: "mmhm..."

y: "the stars look like they are falling down..."

c: "..."

c: "i had been extremely insecure..."

c: "the world is so big... yet i fear that one day i disappear without learning anything about it..."

c: "but as yuuri held my hand just now while climbing these dark stairs..."

c: "i started to feel as if i were one with the entire world..."

c: "then i started feeling... what i see and touch, are everything the world has in it."

c: "even if i put it like this, it is probably still hard to comprehend..."

y: "i get you."

y: "i have been meaning to say so myself."

c: "rich coming from yuuri..."

*

"ah.. the sun's rising"

"let's head to the edge. it's nearer there."

"woah..."

"so now we are the happiest people in the world."

"is that so..."

"if i am the happiest, will chito be the second happiest?"

"i am alright with being the second as well..."

*

"so this is the last packet of food..."

"so... what will we do next?"

"god knows..."

"well, let's eat our fill first..."

"and nap a little..."

"and leave the rest for later..."

"....."

the end

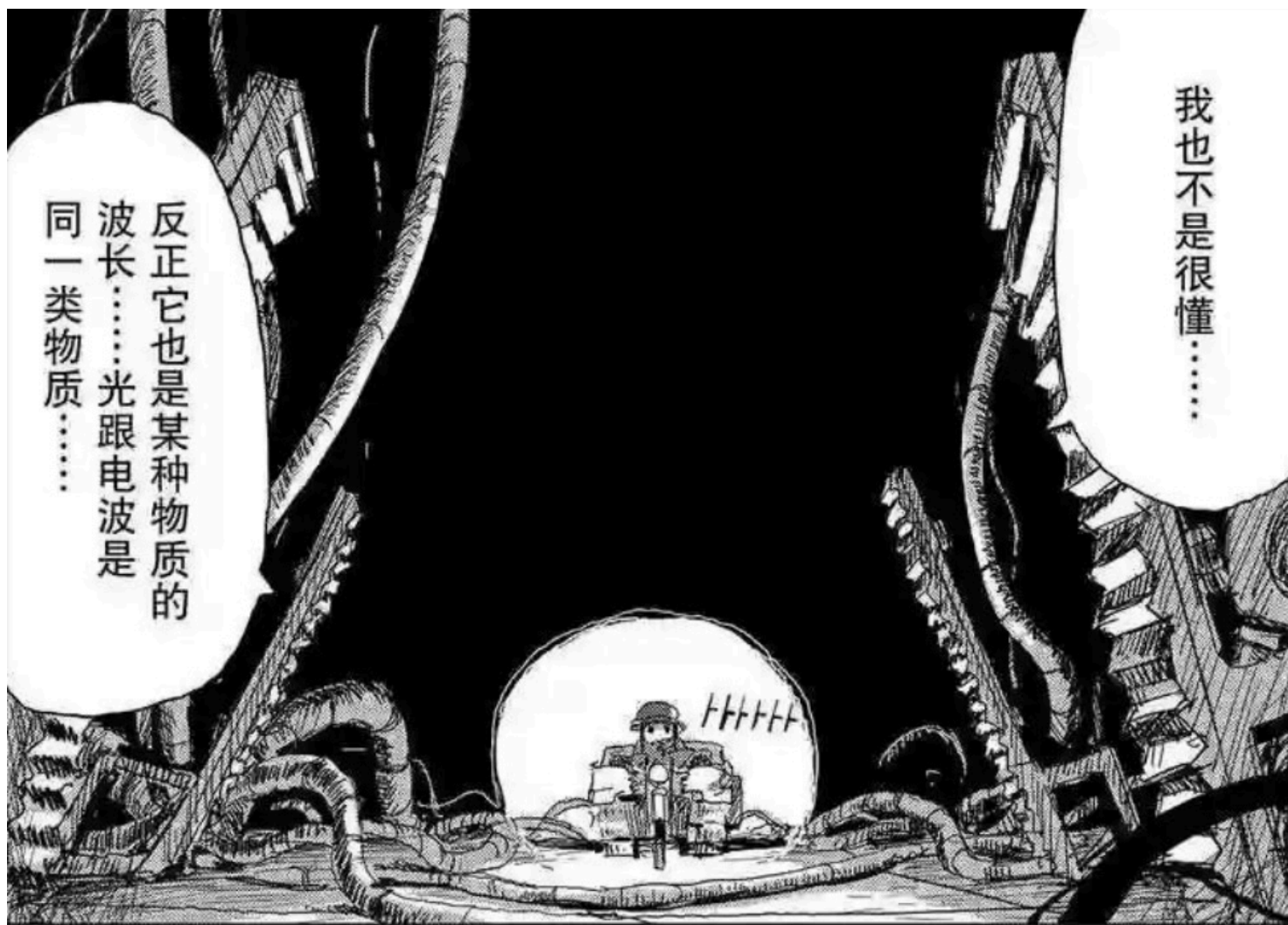
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我也不是很懂……

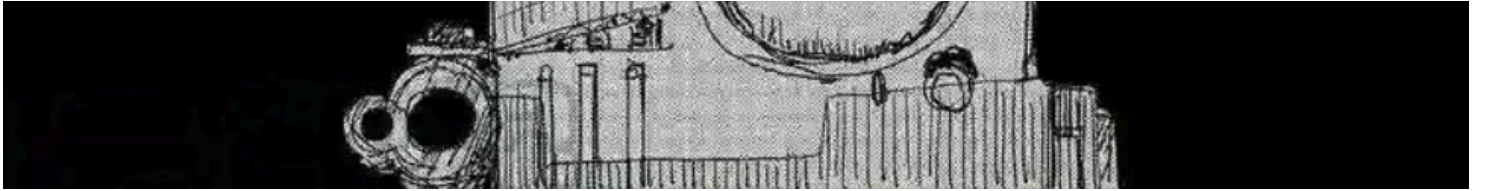
反正它也是某种物质的
波长……光跟电波是
同一类物质……

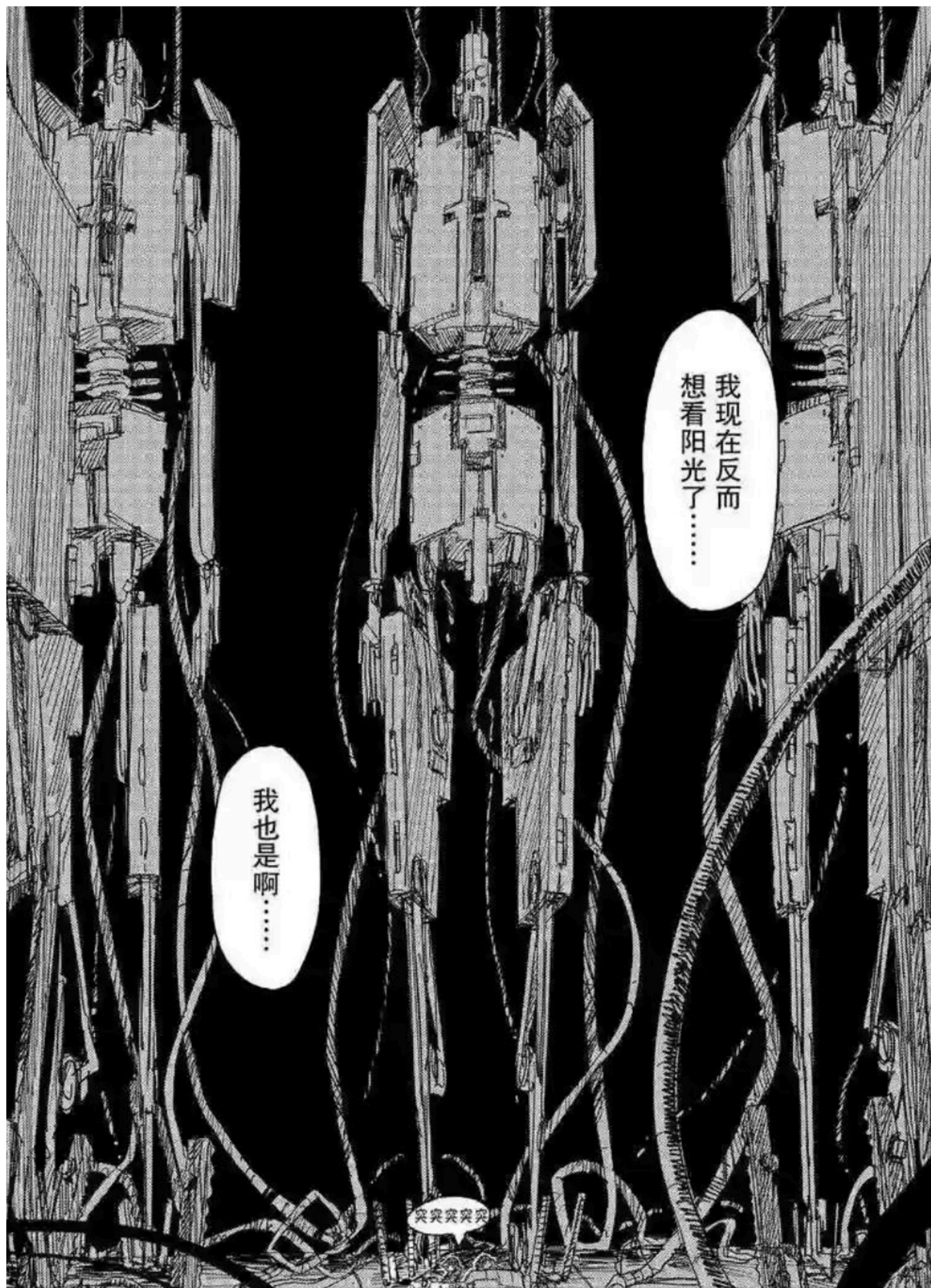


这样……
那我见到光之后心情
是不是也会变得愉快
起来？

看到街灯……
之类的？



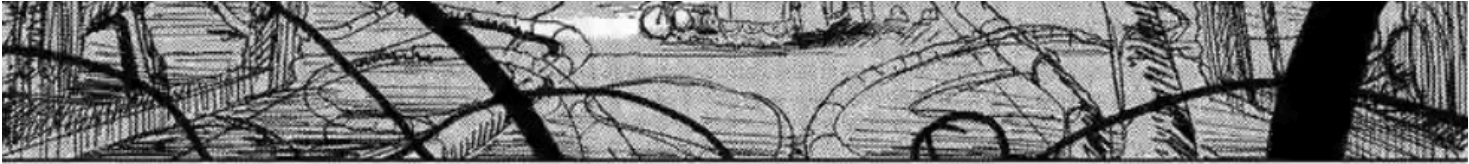




我现在反而
想看阳光了……

我也是啊……

突突突突突





虽然我们一直
都只有两个人……

来，小翠，
我是你爸爸哦！

她在说
「我讨厌爸爸」呢。

那我们在整合一下
意见，然后再另行
报告……

我可没说过
这话啊……

但当知道以前的人
是过着这样的生活的
时候，



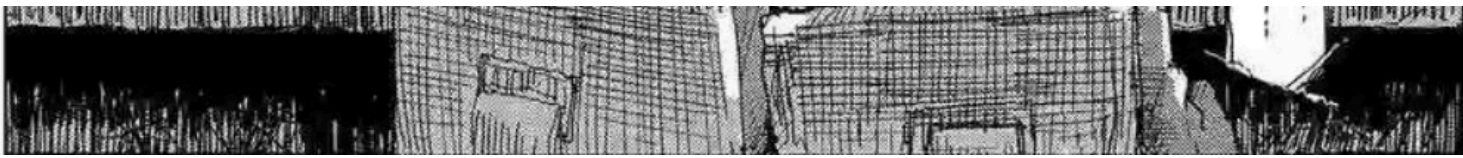
就感觉没那么
寂寞了。

所以我把薯条
买回来了……

这都怪爸爸……

是啊。

没想到你这人
还听舍吃的……



后记

为什么战争永不停息，为什么人与人之间永远无法和平共处……

我至今看了 113113 本书，一直在思考这两个问题。

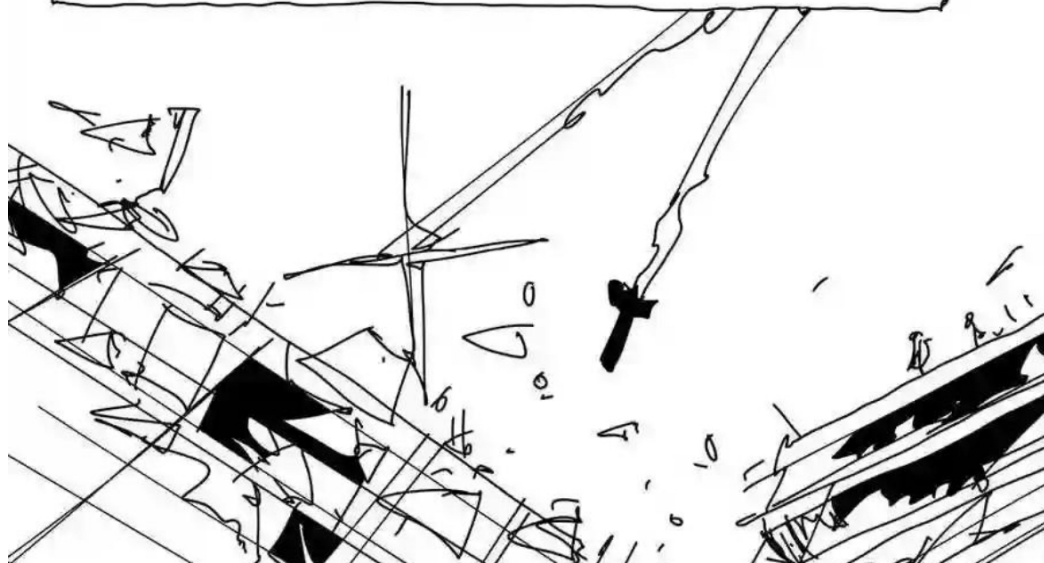
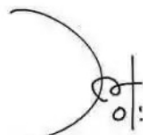
我尝试去解开这些谜团，又或者根据自身的理想对现实加以幻想……

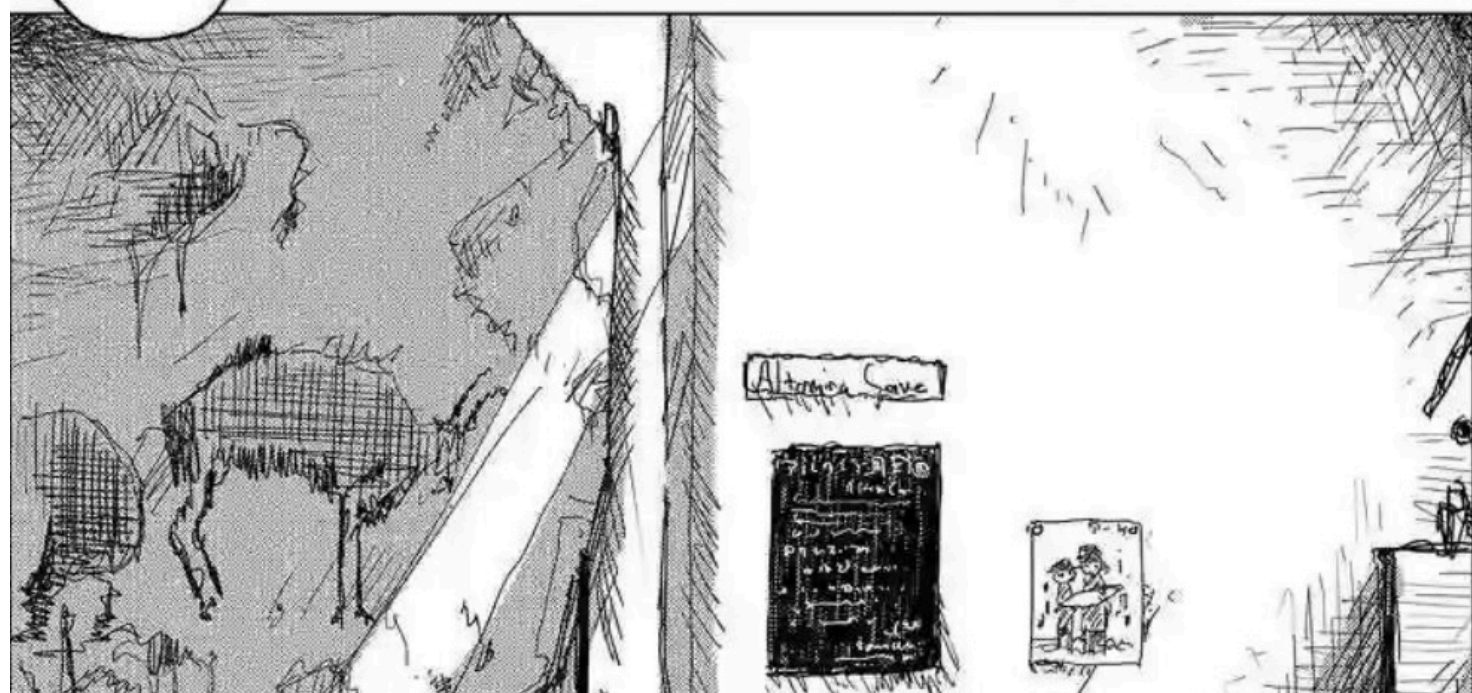
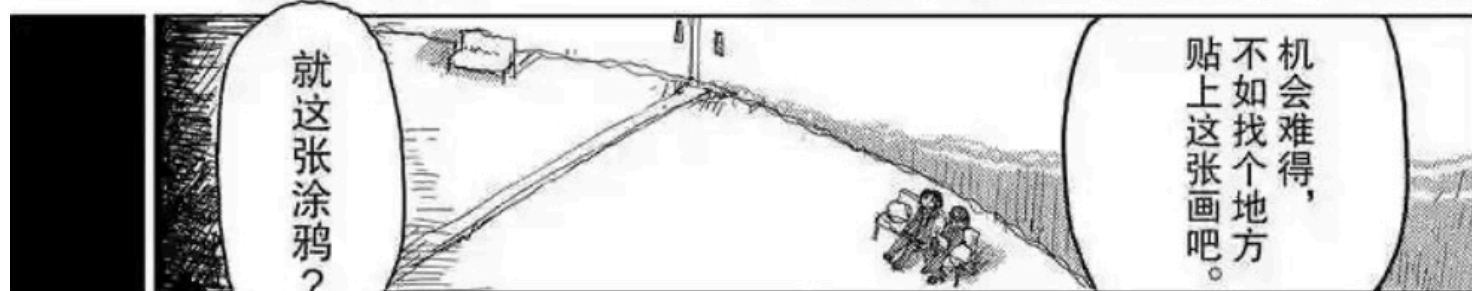
结果还是搞不懂，甚至还觉得不耐烦了。

思考是一件很累的事。

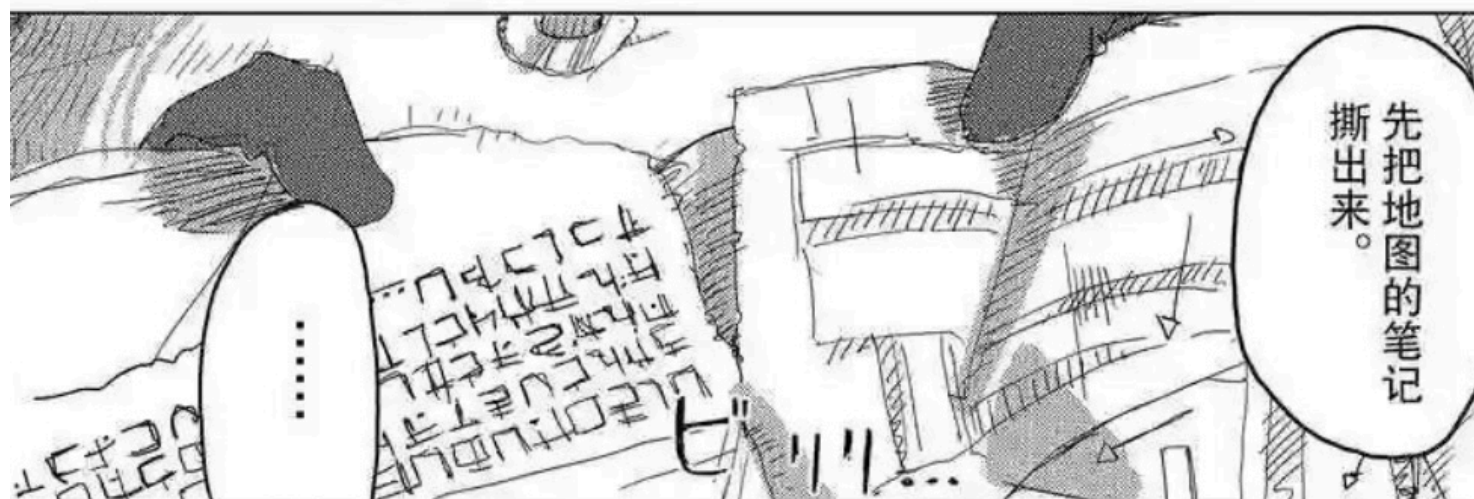
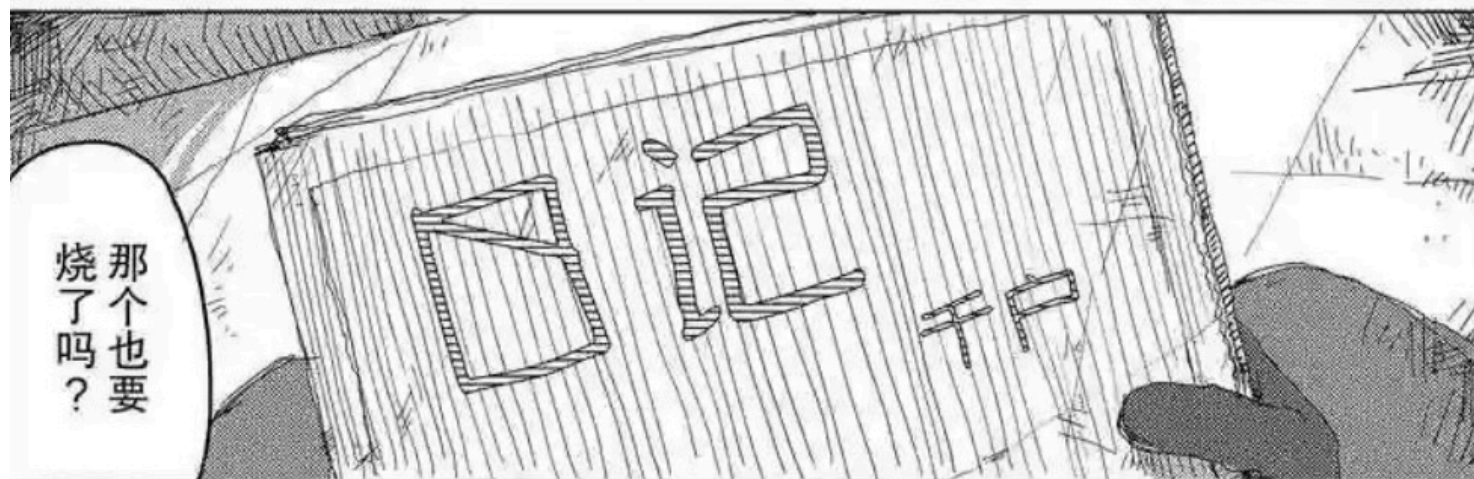
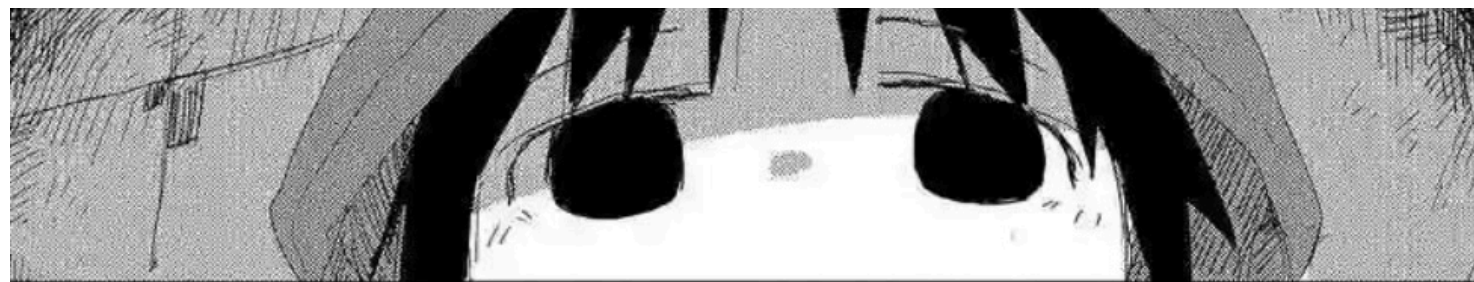
这种过于现实的观点也许无法让人感到幸福。

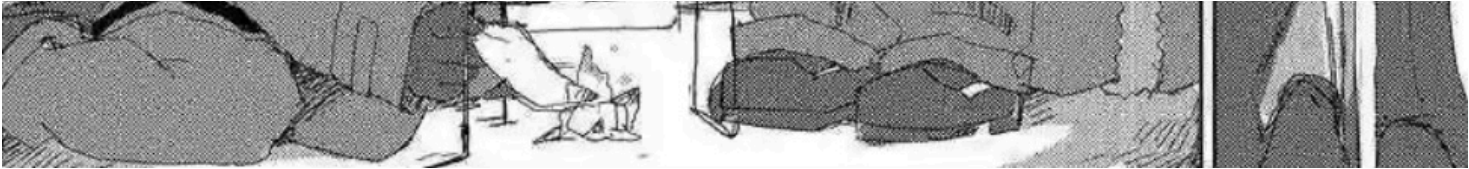
因此我现在想回老家，过着每天都能摸一下种在老家院子里的柿子树的生活。













可能我只是
害怕忘记而已。



就像无梦的
深睡一样……



自己的记忆
突然裂开了
一个小洞。

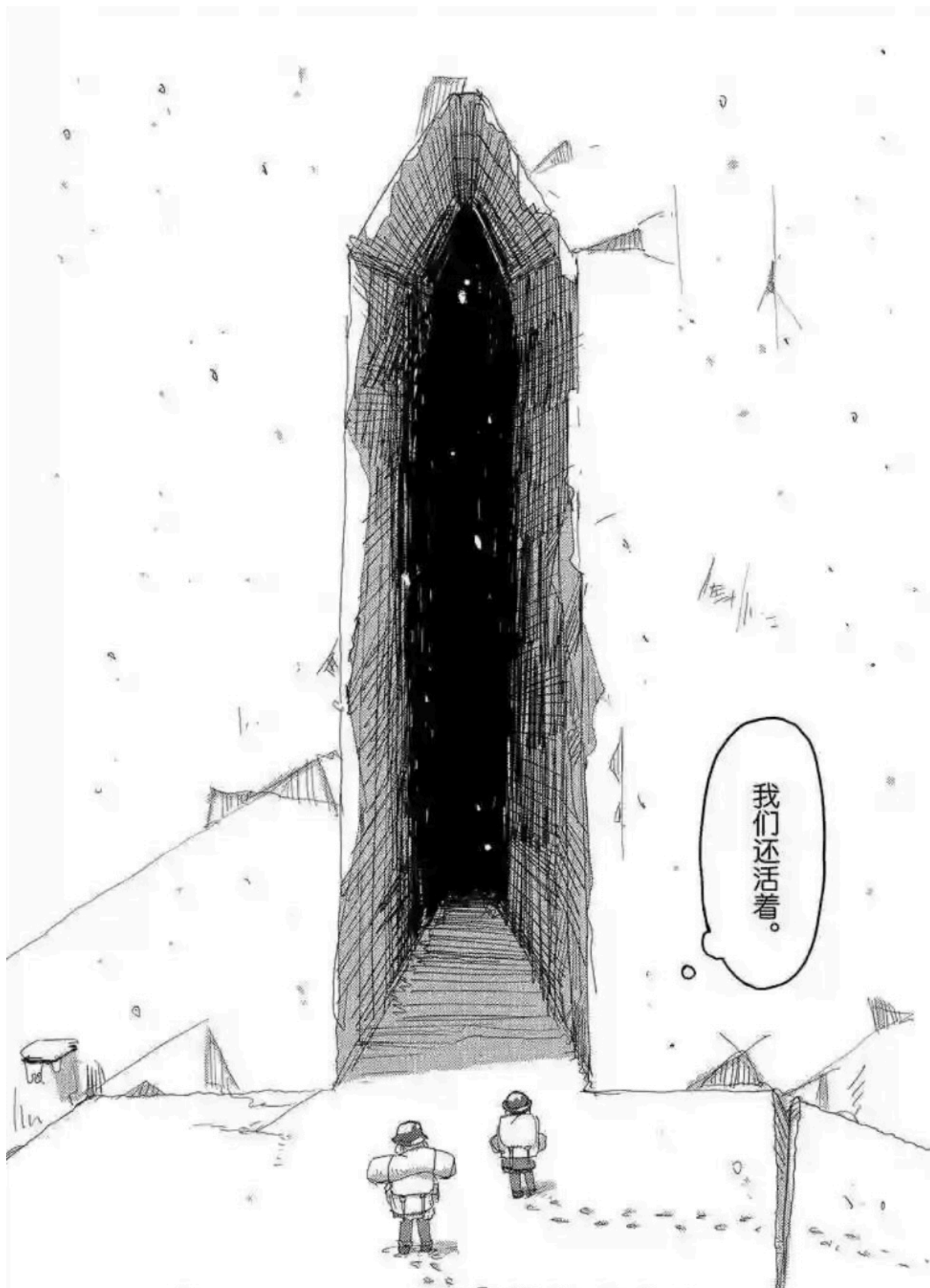


因为我们
每天都会醒来……



不过
没关系。





我们还活着。





